



AA-52 machine gun

The **AA-52** (full designation in French: *Arme Automatique Transformable Modèle 1952*, "Transformable automatic weapon model 1952") is one of the first French-produced guns of the post-World War II era. It was manufactured by the French government-owned *Manufacture d'armes de Saint-Étienne* (MAS) company. The AA-52 is still used today as a vehicle-mounted weapon due to large quantities in service, but has been replaced in the helicopter role by the Belgian *FN MAG*, starting with the *EC 725 Caracal* of the *special operations units* and the Air Force search and rescue teams. The AA-52 had been largely phased out for infantry use in favour of the lighter *FN Minimi* but remains in use.

History

The AA-52 general-purpose machine gun was conceived and developed following the French military's experiences in the *First Indochina War* during the early 1950s. At that time, the French army was equipped with an assortment of weapons from British and American sources, as well as some German weapons from the Second World War.

Effective supply of ammunition and replacement parts was an almost insoluble task and the army decided to adopt a standard machine gun. The result was the AA-52, conceived for ease of production. The construction is of simple welded stamped sheet steel.

The AA-52 was partially withdrawn from the service of the French army in 2008. It was replaced in the 2010s by 10,881 *FN MAG* general-purpose machine guns.^{[9][10]}

AA-52



AA-52 mounted on a *Leclerc* main battle tank

Type	<i>General-purpose machine gun</i>
Place of origin	France
Service history	
In service	1952–present
Used by	See <i>Users</i>
Wars	<i>Algerian war</i> ^[1] <i>Chadian Civil War</i> ^[2] <i>Shaba II</i> ^[3] <i>Lebanese Civil War</i> ^[4] <i>Gulf War</i> <i>Bosnian War</i> <i>War in Afghanistan</i> <i>Ivorian Civil Wars</i> <i>2011 Libyan uprising</i> ^[5] <i>Syrian Civil War</i> <i>Centrafrican Civil War</i> ^[6] <i>Operation Serval</i> <i>Russo-Ukrainian War</i> ^{[7][8]}
Production history	
Designed	1952
Manufacturer	<i>Manufacture d'armes de Saint-Étienne</i> (MAS)
Variants	NF-1 M.A.C. 58
Specifications	
Mass	9.97 kg (22.0 lb)

Design

The AA-52 is a peculiar weapon among modern machine guns because it uses lever-delayed blowback operation, also seen in the FAMAS rifle, manufactured at the same factory. When firing, the pressure pushing the case head rearward initiates an impulse on a cam that sends the bolt carrier rearward. After a certain distance, a link (in this case the firing pin) pulls the bolt head, hence extracting the spent case. Since there is no primary extraction, the chamber is fluted to allow powder gases to flow back, unsticking the case from the chamber wall as with Heckler & Koch-type roller-delayed blowback weapons.

The feed and trigger mechanisms are derived from the MG 42.

The AA-52 can be used as a light machine gun with a bipod or as a heavy machine gun with a tripod. When used with a tripod for continuous fire, the gun is fitted with a heavier barrel. In the light machine gun configuration, the AA-52 is a relatively light weapon to carry. The AA-52 can be fired from the shoulder, but this is slightly awkward because of the position of the handle; however, the bipod can be used as a handguard when not in use. The barrel is changed by pressing a latch and rotating it a quarter of a turn. The APX(SOM) telescopic sight used on the MAS-49 and the FR-F1 sniper rifle can be mounted on the AA-52 as well as an infrared night sight.

Length	1,080 mm (43 in)
Barrel length	600 mm (24 in)
Cartridge	<u>7.5×54mm French</u> <u>7.62×51mm NATO</u>
Caliber	7.5 mm 7.62 mm
Action	<u>Lever-delayed blowback</u>
Rate of fire	900 round/min
Muzzle velocity	830 m/s (2,700 ft/s)
Effective firing range	600 m (660 yd)
Maximum firing range	3,200 m (3,500 yd)
Feed system	50-round non-disintegrating belt
Sights	Iron Removable APX (SOM) telescopic sights IR scope



AA-52 machine gun on display.

Variants

NF-1

The AA-52 originally used the standard 7.5×54mm French cartridge. The general adoption of the 7.62×51mm NATO cartridge reduced the opportunity for export sales, and the gun was adapted for this standard NATO calibre. The new, adapted gun was designated **AANF-1** (also **ANF-1** or **NF-1**).^[11]

MAC-58

The **MAC-58** was a version of the AA-52 chambered in .50 BMG. A few prototypes were tested and one retained for preserial production, but it never reached production due to the large quantity of US M2 Browning machine guns already in service with the French armed forces.

Users

-  Argentina^[12]
-  Belgium: Twin AA-52 machine guns were found in Fouga Magister attack aircraft.^[13]
-  Benin^[14]
-  Bolivia ^[15]
-  Burkina Faso^[14]
-  Cameroon^[16]

-  Central African Republic^[14]
-  Comoros^[14]
-  Côte d'Ivoire^[14]
-  Djibouti^[14]
-  Dominican Republic
-  France: F1 variant.^[14]
-  Gabon^[14]
-  Georgia: used some ANF1 to protect Camp Warehouse, Afghanistan, under French command.^[17]
-  Indonesia: AAT-F1 variant mounted on AMX-10 PAC 90 of Korps Marinir.^[18]
-  Ireland: Twin AA-52 7.62mm machine guns were fitted to the Irish Panhard AML 60-7 CS armoured cars.^[19]
-  Ivory Coast^[20]
-  Lebanon mounted on VAB mephisto
-  Madagascar^[14]
-  Mali: Armed and Security Forces of Mali^[14]
-  Mauritania^[14]
-  Morocco: F1 variant.^[14]
-  Niger^[14]
-  Senegal^[14]
-  Seychelles^[14]
-  Somalia^[14]
-  Togo^[14]
-  Tunisia^[21]
-  Ukraine^[22]



Pick-up of the Police of the Central African Republic with an AA-52 machine gun on the roof.

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External links

- AAT Mod.52 / Mod. F1 (<http://modernfirearms.net/en/machineguns/france-machineguns/aat-mod-52-eng/>) at Modern Firearms

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